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Embracing the competition: Bengaluru, one of this year's Women's Premier League T20 venues, has enthusiastically welcomed the event. RAJDEEP SAHA

No longer an undercard, and a fast game ignites a gentle-paced city!

Our correspondents share **candid moments and firsthand experiences** from covering the WPL matches in Vadodara and Bengaluru.

"People don't watch the WPL here. Well, they do, but not as much as the IPL. You can't even get tickets for the IPL," an auto driver candidly remarked when asked if there were any signs of Women's Premier League fever in the Garden City.

After a four-hour train journey from Chennai to Bengaluru and a day spent familiarising itself with the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium, the Diary felt a knot in its stomach. After all, this was its first outstation assignment — kicked off by Royal Challengers Bengaluru versus Mumbai Indians, a rivalry for the ages in Indian franchise cricket.

But before the Diary could dwell on its nerves, it was pleasantly surprised to see the auto driver's claim being challenged. Yes, there were fans in Virat Kohli jerseys. One RCB supporter even had 'RO45' painted on his face — a choice that left the Diary somewhat perplexed. Yet, among them were also those who had turned up purely for the